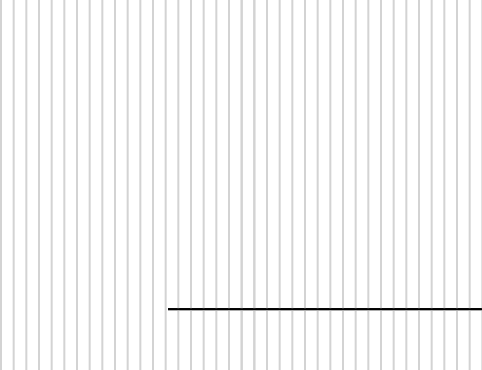




The Unified Protocol for Transdiagnostic Treatment of Emotional Disorders

Module Handouts and Homework Forms

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Understanding our Emotions and our Behavior (The ARCs)

Emotions are a natural part of our daily lives. Experiencing emotions is not problematic in and of itself. In order to understand *how* or *when* our emotions become problematic or begin to interfere with our lives, we need to understand the situation or *context* in which our emotions and behavior occurs.

A large part of treatment will involve being better able to understand and identify the situations or events that precede and may trigger our emotions and the consequences of our emotional reactions. We call this skill identifying the “ARC” of your emotional experiences.

The As - Antecedents – Situations that precede or trigger your emotions & emotional reactions

Something precedes us behaving in a particular way. For example, when you are driving and someone cuts you off, you then get angry and might even yell. In this case, knowing that you were cut off while driving helps us to understand why you responded by getting angry and yelling.

In addition to events that occur immediately before we react, more distant events can also influence our emotions and behavior. Building on our previous example, suppose that earlier in the day you had gotten into a fight with a significant other (family member, partner, friend, etc.) and then someone cuts you off on the freeway later that day. This earlier fight could also influence how you respond to being cut off.

The Rs - Responses – The emotional reaction you may have in response to these situations

This is the behavior or emotional reaction in question. In the above example, the Bs would be getting angry and yelling.

The Cs - Consequences – What happens afterwards or as a result of your emotional reaction

Our behaviors have consequences. For example, after getting angry and yelling you might discover that you know the person and that they were rushing to the hospital with a sick child. You then

feel embarrassed and/or ashamed. In this case, both the reaction and the event that preceded your reaction help us to understand the consequences.

This is a very important skill, and one that we will be spending a lot of time practicing. You can use this skill in the future to help solve problems or deal with any setbacks you might experience.

Definitions of Emotions

The following are some definitions of emotions we talked about during session. These, of course, are not all of the emotions we experience, but these examples will begin to give you an idea of some of the ways emotions function in our lives.

Fear

Fear is nature's alarm system. It is a basic response to danger and signals the need for immediate attention and action.

Sadness/Depression

Sadness/depression is extreme dejection, melancholy, and a sense of hopelessness and inadequacy, which is a natural response to loss of a loved one, or a personal set back for which no solutions are obvious. It signals the need for withdrawal and reduction of activity so that mourning may take place, resources can be gathered, and the event can be processed appropriately.

Anxiety

Anxiety is a future-oriented emotion. It is a basic response to the perceived unpredictability of, or lack of control over, upcoming, potentially negative or dangerous events. It signals the need to be vigilant, reduce activity, and refocus attention on possible sources of future threat or danger. When we feel anxious, our bodies and minds get into a state of "preparation" so that we aren't caught off guard if something bad happens.

Anger

Anger is a natural response to the perceived intentional injury, mistreatment, or victimization. It signals the need to increase activity and mobilize efforts to defend oneself or a loved one. Anger is often directed at the perceived source or cause of this threat (or feeling).

Understanding Emotions and Emotion Driven Behaviors (EDBs)

One of the key points about emotions is that under normal circumstances, emotions (e.g., fear, anxiety, sadness/depression, anger, etc.) tell us very important things about what is going on in our lives and motivate us to do something helpful or useful. We call these resulting emotional behaviors “emotion-driven behaviors,” or EDBs, because they are hard to resist (or change) when we get emotional.

Some examples of EDBs:

Fear

Imagine you are walking down the street and a car comes screeching down toward you, you jump on to the sidewalk and pull your friend away from the car.

What is the EDB?

Jumping out of the way.

Sadness/Depression

Imagine you find out that a very close friend or family member has passed away. You will probably feel intense sadness/depression and a great sense of loss. You are also likely to feel as if you have no energy and it is difficult to focus on anything except for disorganized thoughts of your loved one and how you will cope. You may also feel numb, and that the loss hasn't really “sunk in.” These are typical responses to experiencing a tragedy or traumatic event. As a result, you might find that you are unable to do much of anything other than focus on the loss in an effort to help yourself cope.

What is the EDB?

Decreasing activities, focusing on the loss.

Anxiety

Imagine that you have a big presentation coming up at work/school, which is going to be very important for your job/grade. Naturally, you start to think about it more often as the date approaches and you might even start to feel anxious. So, you start doing some research on the topic – maybe you even stay really late at the library to make sure you have all the information you need. You make the presentation and practice it several times (you might even ask a

friend or family member to give you feedback on it). You'll even anticipate some of the questions people might ask so that you know how you will respond. On the day of the presentation, you'll probably get up early, put on your best suit and go over the presentation again.

What is the EDB?

Preparing for the presentation, to avoid doing badly.

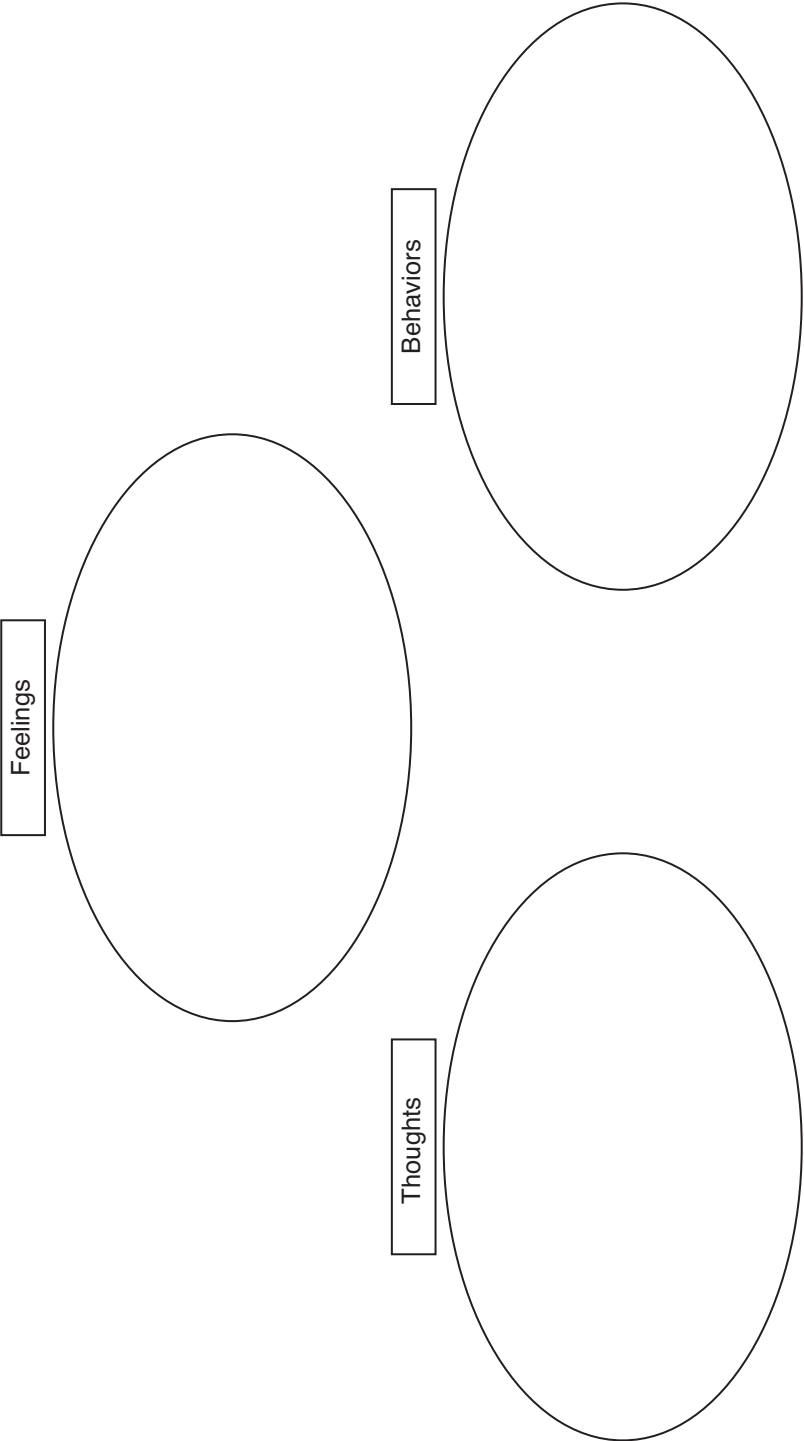
Anger

Imagine that you are driving in your car on the freeway when someone suddenly cuts you off. You have to slam on your brakes to avoid hitting the other driver. You honk your horn and yell at the other driver, perhaps even cursing, and experiencing a strong impulse to go after them.

What is the EDB?

Honking the horn and yelling.

Three-Component Model of Emotion



Monitoring Emotions and EDBs in Context

As Antecedents		Rs Responses		Cs Consequences	
Date/Time	Situation, Triggers	Thoughts	Feelings	Behaviors	What happened next?

Decisional Balance Worksheet

Thinking about changing or coming into treatment can be scary. When we think about changing, we often don't consider all "sides" in a complete way. Instead, we do what we think we "should" do and avoid doing things we don't feel like doing. We might even just feel confused or overwhelmed and give up thinking about it at all. Thinking through the pros and cons of *both* changing *and* staying the same, is one way to help us fully consider a possible change and help the process feel more manageable. This can also help us cope with difficult times that might arise along the way. Write all the pros and cons you can think of for both changing and staying the same in the boxes below.

	Pros/Benefits	Cons/Costs
Change		
Stay the Same		

Treatment Goal Setting Worksheet

Research has consistently shown that one of the most effective ways to achieve successful behavior change is goal setting. When we talk about goals, we are referring to future states or events that we are interested in making happen or hoping to prevent from happening. These can include more immediate things, such as: “going to the gym tonight” or “finishing my treatment homework” and more distant things, such as: “making more friends” and “feeling happier.” Research has also shown that setting specific, concrete, and manageable goals for behavior change greatly improves our chances of successfully changing. Although you might have a general sense of what your goals for treatment are, it will be helpful to explicitly record these goals on this worksheet. Next, you will outline a series of smaller goals or steps that will help you to achieve your larger, more distant treatment goals. Take a moment to think about your most important goal that you have for yourself during treatment.

My #1 goal for treatment is: _____

Making it More Concrete

Now, let’s take a moment to make this goal more concrete. What would it look like once you have achieved this goal? What things would you be doing, or not doing? What behaviors would you be engaging in? What behaviors would you *not* be engaging in? Try to be as concrete as possible here.

Taking the Necessary Steps

Next, think about some small manageable steps that you can take towards reaching the specific treatment goals you’ve listed above. These steps should take anywhere from a few days or a week up to a month to achieve. What steps will you need to take? It can be

helpful to work backwards from your goal to help identify specific steps you will need to take to get there. Use the behaviors you listed above to help come up with your steps to achieving your treatment goal.

Step 5:

Step 4:

Step 3:

Step 2:

Step 1:

People often have at least a few goals for treatment. Let's take a moment to list at least two more treatment goals you have. You might find it helpful to repeat this process for additional goals as well.

My 2nd goal for treatment is: _____

Making it More Concrete

Take a moment to make this goal more concrete. What would it look like once you have achieved this goal? What things would you be doing, or not doing? What behaviors would you be engaging in or *not* engaging in? Again, be as concrete as possible here, try to list specific behaviors.

Taking the Necessary Steps

Next, think about some small manageable steps that you can take towards reaching the specific treatment goals you've listed above. These steps should take anywhere from a few days or a week up to a month to achieve. What steps will you need to take? It can be helpful to work backwards from your goal to help identify specific steps you will need to take to get there. Use the behaviors you listed above to help come up with your steps to achieving your treatment goal.

Step 5:

Step 4:

Step 3:

Step 2:

Step 1:

My 3rd goal for treatment is:

Making it More Concrete

Take a moment to make this goal more concrete. What would it look like once you have achieved this goal? What things would you be doing, or not doing? What behaviors would you be engaging in or *not* engaging in? Again, be as concrete as possible here, try to list specific behaviors.

Taking the Necessary Steps

Next, think about some small manageable steps that you can take towards reaching the specific treatment goals you've listed above. These steps should take anywhere from a few days or a week up to a month to achieve. What steps will you need to take? It can be helpful to work backwards from your goal to help identify specific steps you will need to take to get there. Use the behaviors you listed above to help come up with your steps to achieving your treatment goal.

Step 5:

Step 4:

Step 3:

Step 2:

Step 1:

Practicing Emotional Awareness

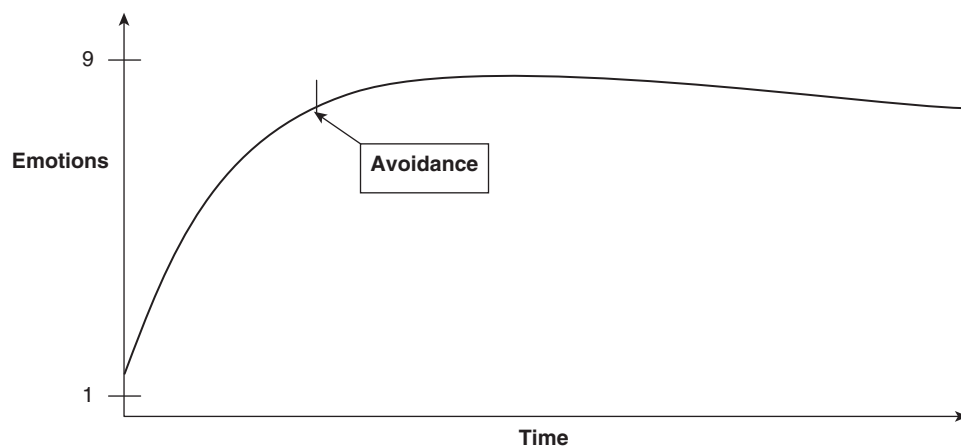
The first step in changing how we experience and respond to our emotions is to practice accurate awareness of our emotions.

Components of “emotional awareness”

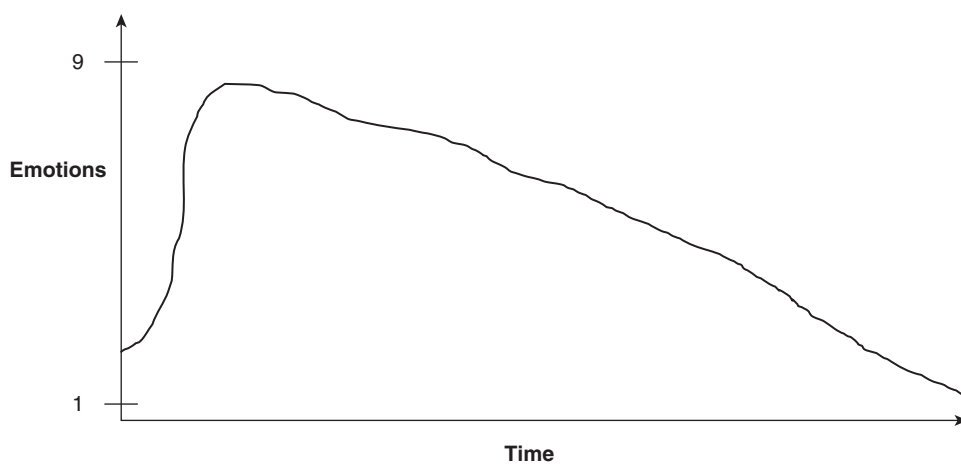
1. Allowing oneself to fully experience emotions as they happen.
2. Focusing on being in the present moment, not “living” in the future or in the past.
3. Noticing thoughts, feelings, and behaviors that are occurring at that moment.
4. Allowing emotions to come and go, without trying to push away feelings or trying to hold on to certain feelings. When you allow yourself to experience a negative emotion, then you are able to process it and move forward. If you don't give yourself permission to experience the emotion but push it away, then it becomes a “tidal wave” of emotion that feels very out of control.
5. Being aware of your emotions does not always “feel good.” However, it will allow you to move past the experience, instead of getting stuck trying to push it away, which only reinforces its power.
6. Awareness does not necessarily mean acceptance of the situation or environment. Instead, we are focusing on acceptance of one's emotional reaction to it, before possibly acting in a different way.
7. Having some understanding for one's own emotional experience. Getting “mad” or “frustrated” with yourself or saying “I'm so stupid for feeling this way” will only make you want to control and resist emotional experience even more. This treatment focuses on increasing the range of emotional experience, instead of attempting to restrict it. This includes allowing oneself to be sad, frustrated, anxious, as well as *letting it pass*.

Natural Course of Emotions

When we do things to try to avoid our emotions or stop them from occurring when they are at their most intense peak in a given situation, we add fuel to that emotion and will associate that situation in the future with these intense emotions.

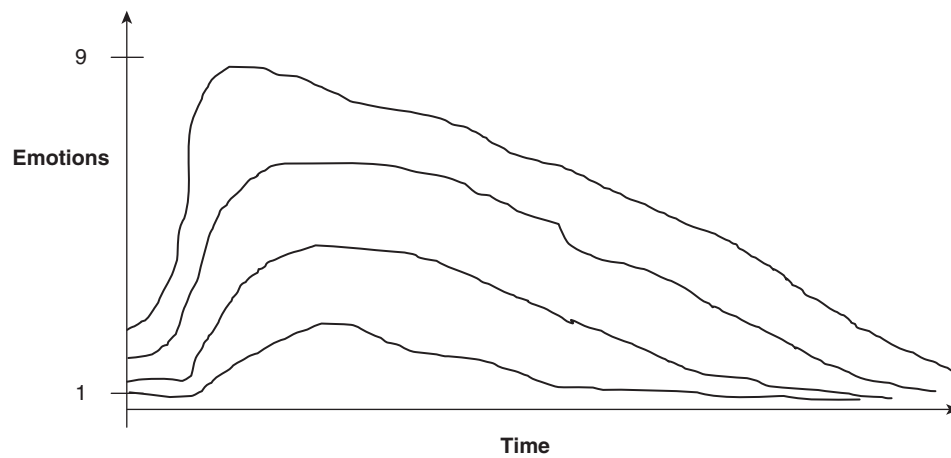


However, if we allow them to just happen, without trying to avoid them or stop them from occurring, the intensity of emotions will actually start to decrease. This is the natural course of emotions. By allowing them to run their course, we can begin to associate a given situation with the natural ebb and flow of emotion, knowing **what goes up, must come down**.



Natural Course of Emotions

In fact, by letting our emotions just happen in a given situation, without trying to change them or control them or stop them from occurring, we will start to experience our emotions as less and less intense each time we are faced with the same situation in the future. We have allowed ourselves to see that **what goes up, must come down**, and have learned that we can in fact “ride the wave” of our emotions and cope with the situation.



Mood Induction Recording Form

The purpose of this exercise is to practice noticing the thoughts, physical sensations/feelings, and behaviors that come up during an emotional experience. Try to find music and/or songs that bring up strong emotions for you. As you listen, note your reactions to the music and/or the songs you have selected. Use this form to record what you noticed after listening to each piece. What was your first emotional response? How strongly did you feel these initial emotions? What was your reaction to this initial emotional response - what thoughts, sensations, or feelings did you experience? Rate the intensity of your emotional experience using the 0–10 point scale below:

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10
Not at all A Little Moderately Quite a Bit Extremely

	Initial Emotional Response	Intensity of Emotional Response	Reaction to Emotional Response		
<i>Song Name</i>	Describe emotions you experienced	Rate how strongly you felt these emotions	Describe thoughts	Describe sensations or feelings	Describe behaviors (e.g., fidgeting, pacing, sighing)

Anchoring in the Present

At least once per day, practice anchoring yourself to the present by noticing at least one thing going on around you. This can be a sound you hear, something you see, or something you can physically feel (like your chair, a computer keyboard, a dish sponge). You can use your breath to help anchor yourself to the present moment. The goal of this exercise is not to think about the meaning of what you notice, nor is it to try to understand your reaction to it. The purpose of this exercise is simply to practice paying attention to what is going on around you *right now*. Also record any thoughts, feelings (physical sensations) or behaviors that you may have noticed.

	<u>What did you notice?</u>	<u>How effective were you at anchoring yourself in the present?</u> 0 – 10 (not at all) (extremely)
Sun		
Mon		
Tues		
Wed		
Thurs		
Fri		
Sat		

Non-Judgmental, Present Focused Emotional Awareness

Set aside a time, at least twice per day, to deliberately practice non-judgmental present-focused awareness. The goal of this exercise is to get used to paying attention to what is happening inside and around you in the moment, observing your thoughts, physical sensations/feelings, and behaviors. Practice acknowledging thoughts and feelings just as they are, letting go of the need to critically judge, change, or avoid your inner experience. With increased practice, these techniques will become more automatic and eventually can become a skill used at any time throughout the day and in any situation.

		<u>What did you notice?</u>			<u>How effective were you at not judging your experience?</u>
	Practice	<u>Thoughts</u>	<u>Physical Sensations/Feelings</u>	<u>Behaviors</u>	0 - 10 (not at all) (extremely)
Sun	1.				
	2.				
Mon	1.				
	2.				
Tues	1.				
	2.				
Wed	1.				
	2.				
Thurs	1.				
	2.				
Fri	1.				
	2.				
Sat	1.				
	2.				

[illegible]

Common “Thinking Traps”

Probability Overestimation (a.k.a. “Jumping to Conclusions”): When you overestimate the likelihood of negative events happening. You interpret things negatively when there is little or no evidence to support that interpretation. Similarly, you may ignore evidence that would suggest another, perhaps more likely outcome. Some common examples of *Probability Overestimation* include:

Catastrophizing (a.k.a. “Thinking the Worst”): When you automatically predict that the worst possible scenario is going to happen, without considering other possible outcomes. You also tend to underestimate your ability to cope with this outcome if it does occur. Some common examples of *Catastrophizing* include:

Evaluating Automatic Appraisals

Questions to ask when evaluating automatic appraisals

Countering Probability Overestimation - Learning to reevaluate Jumping to Conclusions

1. Do I know for certain that _____ will happen?
2. Am I 100% sure these awful consequences will occur?
3. What evidence do I have for this fear or belief?
4. What happened in the past in this situation?
5. Do I have a crystal ball? How can *I be sure that I know the answer?*
6. Could there be any other explanations?
7. How much does it *feel* like _____ will happen? What is the *true likelihood* that _____ will happen?
8. Is my negative prediction driven by the intense emotions I'm experiencing?
9. Is _____ really so important or consequential?

Decatastrophizing - Learning to reevaluate Thinking the Worst

1. What is the worst that could happen? How bad is that?
2. If _____ happened, could I cope with it? How would I handle it?
3. So what?
4. Even if _____ happens, can I live through it?
5. Have I been able to cope with _____ in the past?
6. Is _____ really so terrible?

Given the answers to these questions, what is an alternative way of looking at this situation?

Our emotions can drive us to behave in a particular way. For instance, fear may cause us to escape or avoid danger, anger may lead us to attack or defend ourselves, and sadness might lead us to withdraw and reduce our energy levels. In the appropriate circumstances, these types of emotion driven behaviors, or EDBs, can be helpful. However, sometimes EDBs can interfere with our lives. For example, when we feel sad it is common to not feel like doing anything or to withdraw from social interaction. This can be an adaptive response to sadness, providing us with time to pause, reflect, and put events into perspective. However, if every time we experience sadness we engage in these same EDBs in response (perhaps in an attempt to alleviate the intensity of the sadness), they can begin to interfere with our life. These EDBs will begin occurring more frequently and rigidly, losing their connection to the context in which they are occurring. This is when EDBs begin to interfere with our lives.

Research has shown this to be one of the most effective ways for breaking this cycle is by engaging in behaviors that are the exact opposite of what our emotions are driving us to do – in essence *countering EDBs*. By going against the automatic behaviors our emotions are driving us to do, we can begin to break the cycle of unhelpful EDBs, and can actually change how our emotions are experienced. For example, if the EDBs for sadness are withdrawal and activity reduction, in order to counter these EDBs we would start engaging more in activities. Engaging in opposite behaviors are effective strategies to counter unhelpful EDBs that have become less useful to us and have begun interfering with the ability to fully live our lives. This strategy can be applied to the full range of emotional experiences. Below, are some examples of common EDBs and associated incompatible behaviors for effectively Countering EDBs.

EDB(s)	Incompatible Behaviors
Calling relatives to check on their safety	Restricting contact/calling relatives
Perfectionistic behavior at work or home	Leaving things untidy or unfinished
Checking locks, stove, or other appliances	Repeatedly locking/unlocking and turning on/off until memory is unclear
Leaving (escaping from) a theater, religious service, or other crowded area	Move to the center of the crowd; smile or produce non-fearful facial expressions
Social withdrawal	Scheduling and engaging in social activities
Leaving (escaping) a social situation	Staying in situation and approaching people
Verbally/physically attacking someone when in an argument	Remove self from situation and/or practice relaxation techniques
Hypervigilance	Focus attention on specific task at hand; meditation; relaxation

Identifying Automatic Appraisals

SITUATION / TRIGGER	AUTOMATIC APPRAISAL(s)	EMOTION(s)	IDENTIFY “THINKING TRAP”

Identifying & Evaluating Automatic Appraisals

SITUATION/ TRIGGER	AUTOMATIC APPRAISAL(s)	EMOTION(s)	IDENTIFY “THINKING TRAP”	GENERATE ALTERNATIVE APPRAISAL(s)

What are EDBs?

EDBs are Emotion Driven Behaviors. These are actions we tend to take in response to intense emotions. They are behaviors driven by the emotion itself. EDBs are a natural response to emotions that can motivate us to act in ways that are helpful to us, such as fear motivating us to jump out of the way of a moving car. But sometimes EDBs can be less helpful.

When are EDBs NOT helpful?

If we are habitually acting in ways that ultimately allow us to escape our emotions, these emotion driven behaviors are not as useful or helpful to us. These EDBs are actually functioning as emotion avoidance strategies, and may motivate us to act in ways that make threatening or intense situations continue to feel threatening and intense.

Here are some examples:

Example 1:

You feel anxious at work, and are concerned your boss or your coworkers don't think you are doing a good enough job. You automatically respond by pushing yourself to be the "perfect" employee. In this case, pushing yourself to be perfect is the emotion driven behavior – your anxiety about being negatively evaluated are driving you to perform at a level that will allow you to avoid criticism. However, trying to be "perfect" (which is one way of trying to establish control over a seemingly uncontrollable threatening situation) usually leads to higher and higher standards for work, and more anxiety about additional tasks. You now have anxiety not only about being evaluated negatively, but also about being able to do what it takes to be perfect.

The EDB – trying to do work "perfectly"

The consequences –

Short Term

You feel more in control

Long Term

You now have anxiety about being evaluated negatively *and* getting your work done perfectly

Example 2:

You wake up feeling depressed and unable to face the day. Instead of going to work, you decide to stay home and sleep, even though you know you have sympathetic friends at work. In this case, the EDB is staying home – your negative emotions are driving you to hole up and hide from the world. However, staying home by yourself also means being alone with your thoughts, and you begin to turn over and over in your mind how sad and down you are, making it worse and worse. In addition, by holing up in your house, you begin to feel isolated and cut off from the world. You now not only feel down, but you also feel lonely and isolated.

The EDB – staying home from working and “hiding” from the world

The consequences –

Short Term

You feel safe and more in control because you will not have to face the day

Long Term

You now not only feel down and depressed but also feel lonely and isolated

Example 3:

You are home alone and begin to feel anxious. You frantically start calling your friends, looking for reassurance. In this case, the EDB is calling your friends – your anxiety about being alone has driven you to seek comfort and reassurance from others. However, the next time you are by yourself, you are faced with the same uncomfortable feelings.

The EDB – calling your friends seeking reassurance

The consequences –

Short Term

You start to calm down and feel less anxious

Long Term

The next time you are alone, you not only feel anxious but also feel unable to cope without the help of your friend

Emotional Avoidance Strategies

One way we attempt to control our emotional experiences is through emotional avoidance. Emotional avoidance strategies can become powerful habits that maintain the cycle of emotions. Emotional avoidance is different from EDBs in that they tend to happen *before* an emotion has a chance to occur, whereas EDBs tend to happen in *response* to an emotion that has already been triggered.

Types of emotional avoidance strategies

1. *Subtle behavioral avoidance*

Subtle behavioral avoidance typically happens when a person enters a situation associated with intense emotions, and escape from the situation is not an option, which results in a variety of subtle behaviors of which the person may not be fully aware. Sometimes these behaviors are related to preventing the physical sensations associated with strong emotions. For example, someone who has frequent panic attacks may avoid drinking caffeinated beverages or go to great lengths to avoid perspiring by stripping away clothes or turning the thermostat way down to prevent themselves from experiencing physical sensations that may trigger panic. Other behaviors are related to preventing the possibility of experiencing intense emotions. For example, someone who is anxious in social situations may not answer the phone or avoid eye contact in a social engagement that cannot be escaped and may be emotionally arousing. Someone else might avoid emotional greetings or goodbyes.

2. *Cognitive avoidance strategies*

Cognitive avoidance strategies are often difficult to identify, because we may not even be aware we are using these strategies as emotional avoidance. Some common examples of cognitive avoidance strategies are *distraction* (e.g., reading a book, listening to music, watching television) and *“tuning out”* (e.g., pretending we are not in the situation or not fully engaging in the experience of being in the situation). Distraction might seem useful because it keeps our minds from “running away.” But this is also a form of emotional avoidance. For example, someone who worries about the safety of loved ones

may watch television or keep busy when loved ones go out at night. The person is fearful that if he or she does not distract him or herself and prevent negative thoughts and feelings, they will become overwhelming. Rationalization of problems can also be a form of avoidance (different from the cognitive reappraisal techniques discussed previously), if the rationalization is used as an attempt to “push away” emotions as they happen. For example, a person who worries about getting a bad grade on a paper may desperately try to provide reasons why a bad grade would not matter. This would be an emotional avoidance strategy if it were done with the intention of pushing away or avoiding emotions.

3. Safety signals

When someone is unable to directly avoid an emotionally provoking situation, he or she may come to rely on “safety signals” in an attempt to keep emotions from becoming overwhelming. Safety signals are “talismans,” or any items that a person carries that make him/her feel more comfortable, or would be calming in times of extreme distress, despite the lack of any real utility in dealing with a potentially threatening experience. Thus, safety signals have a magical or superstitious quality to them. Common examples of safety signals are water bottles, medication (or empty medication bottles), cell phones, prayer books, pets, etc. Safety signals also prevent us from learning that the situation is not dangerous, as we attribute being able to manage emotions to the presence of the safety signal. Furthermore, the presence of the object reinforces the idea that uncomfortable emotional experiences are unmanageable and overwhelming.

List of Emotional Avoidance Strategies

The purpose of this list is to begin to identify subtle ways that you may attempt to avoid uncomfortable emotions. The list will help you later in treatment when you engage in emotion exposures, so that you can eliminate these counterproductive strategies and ensure that the exposures are as effective as possible. In the “subtle behavioral avoidance” column, list behaviors that you do that help you feel better when you are experiencing intense emotions. These include taking medication, doing deep breathing exercises, etc. In the “cognitive avoidance strategies” column, list any techniques you use to feel better when you are in a situation you cannot physically escape. Some of these strategies include distracting yourself (by watching TV, or listening to the radio), “tuning out” of a conversation with another person, or trying to force yourself to think of something other than the situation at hand. Finally, in the “safety signals” column, list anything that you carry with you, or that you do before going out, that makes you feel more comfortable. This could include carrying a water bottle or medication, having your cell phone with you, carrying the names of your doctor or other important people, etc. If you have trouble figuring out which columns to put a strategy in, that’s okay. The most important part is that you begin to record the variety of emotional avoidance strategies you are engaging in currently.

Subtle Behavioral Avoidance	Cognitive Avoidance	Safety Signals

CHANGING EDBs

Situation / Trigger	Emotion	EDB	New (incompatible) Response	Consequence

1. *Why we have emotions*

It is important to recognize that emotions are not necessarily “bad” or “dangerous,” although they can sometimes feel that way. Often times when people come in for treatment for emotional disorders, they want the therapist to “take away” or “stop” the negative emotions. However, it is important to recognize that this would not be helpful, or adaptive. One of the key points about emotions is that emotions (e.g., fear, anxiety, depression, anger, etc.) tell us very important things about what is going on in our lives and motivate us to do something helpful or useful.

2. *What is an emotion? The 3-component model*

What exactly *is* an emotional experience? Sometimes our emotions might feel like a big “cloud” of intense feelings, and it might seem difficult to identify what our emotions are trying to tell us.

Emotional experiences can actually be broken down into three main parts:

1. Physiological - How I Feel
2. Cognitive - What I Think
3. Behavioral - What I Do

By conducting a *three-point check* and identifying each of these parts, our emotions can begin to feel a bit less overwhelming.

3. *The “ARCs”*

Emotions and EDBs are natural aspects of being human, and are not problematic in and of themselves. However, it is important to understand that our emotions and EDBs occur within a context. Something precedes us responding in a particular way, and how we respond to our emotions has consequences. In order to better understand the context, we use the “ARC” of emotions:

The *As* (*antecedents*) – what precedes an emotion

The *Rs* (*responses*) – your emotional response and behaviors you might engage in as a response to these situations

The *Cs* (*consequences*) – the consequences of those responses

The first step towards better understanding our emotions is through identifying the ABC's of our emotional experiences.

4. Learned behaviors

When we experience strong emotions, they leave lasting impressions. What triggers our emotions, and what happens when we have them, stays with us and influences how we experience similar situations in the future. We learn to repeat things that make us feel good, and to avoid things that make us feel bad. We also may learn to do certain things in order to keep ourselves from potentially feeling bad. These behaviors become well learned and can sometimes be difficult to alter.

5. Non-judgmental emotional awareness

In order to gain a better understanding of our emotions and what they are trying to tell us, it is important to become more aware of our emotional experiences in a non-judgmental way, and the ways in which we respond to these experiences. This is the first, important step towards exploring the role emotional experiences play in our lives. This means learning how to just let your emotions happen when they happen and letting your reactions to them come and go, without trying to reduce them, change them, or judge them as good or bad. This also means learning to become more aware of the whole context in which they occur, including what might have brought them on, how they feel in the moment, and how you might respond to your emotions in a way that will be the most helpful to you, given the context of the current situation you are in.

6. Cognitive reappraisal

In any given situation, there are a large number of different aspects that we can attend to or focus on. Additionally, there are a number of different ways that the aspect of the situation we chose to focus on could be interpreted or appraised. How we interpret or appraise a situation (e.g., which aspects we focus on, how much meaning we assign to them, etc.) has important consequences for our subsequent emotions or how we feel. Similarly, how we feel can influence how

we interpret or appraise situations. Thoughts can influence emotions, and emotions can influence thoughts.

Over time, individuals often develop a particular way or style of appraising situations, and sometimes these automatic appraisals can heavily rely on *thinking traps*, such as probability overestimation or catastrophizing. One way out of these “traps” is to pay attention to the appraisals we have, and evaluate them not as “truths,” but as one possible interpretation of the situation.

7. Emotion Driven Behaviors (EDBs)

Emotion Driven Behaviors (EDBs) are actions we tend to take in response to intense emotions. They are behaviors driven by the emotion itself. EDBs are a natural response to emotions that can motivate us to act in ways that are helpful to us, such as fear motivating us to jump out of the way of a moving car. But sometimes EDBs can be less helpful. If we are habitually acting in ways that ultimately allow us to escape our emotions when they occur, these EDBs are not as useful or helpful to us. These EDBs are actually leading us to avoid our emotions, preventing us from fully experiencing and processing our emotions. They can motivate us to act in ways that make threatening or intense situations or emotions continue to feel threatening and intense.

8. Emotional avoidance strategies

One way we attempt to control our emotional experiences is through emotional avoidance. Emotional avoidance strategies can become powerful habits that maintain the cycle of emotions. Emotional avoidance strategies are different from EDBs in that emotional avoidance strategies tend to happen *before* an emotion has a chance to occur, whereas EDBs tend to happen in *response* to an emotion that has already been triggered. Emotional avoidance strategies include anything used to avoid or reduce the intensity or duration of our emotions in specific situations. These include subtle behavioral avoidance, cognitive avoidance, and safety signals.

Symptom Induction Test Form

Please complete each of the exercises (as described) below. Be sure to engage in each exercise fully, and try to produce at least moderate symptom intensity. After the exercise, please note:

1. the physical symptoms you experienced
2. the **intensity** of the symptoms (0 – 8 scale; 0 = no intensity, 8 = extreme intensity)
3. the level of **distress** you experienced during the task (0 – 8 scale; 0 = no distress, 8 = extreme distress)
4. the degree of **similarity to your naturally occurring symptoms** (0 – 8 scale; 0 = not at all similar, 8 = extremely similar)

Wait until the symptoms have mostly subsided before attempting the next exercise. Use the other spaces provided to be creative and come up with additional exercises that are specific to you. When you are done, pick three of the exercises that produced the most anxiety for you. Put a star next to those exercises.

PROCEDURE	Symptoms Experienced	Intensity	Distress	Similarity
Hyperventilation (60 seconds)				
Breath through thin straw (2 minutes)				
Spinning while standing (60 seconds)				
Running in place (60 seconds)				
Other: (___ seconds)				
Other: (___ seconds)				

Other: (___ seconds)				
Other: (___ seconds)				
Other: (___ seconds)				
Other: (___ seconds)				
Other: (___ seconds)				

Interoceptive Activation Form

Please complete each of the three exercises you chose over the next week. However, this time, you will be engaging in the exercise *repeatedly*, so you notice how your distress about the symptoms decreases the more you are willing to confront it. Be sure to engage in each exercise fully, and try to produce at least moderate symptom intensity. Over time, it will be important to begin to gradually push yourself further and further. After the exercise, please note:

1. The **type of exercise** you chose to do on the line next to DAY
2. the **intensity** of the physical symptoms you experienced (0 – 8 scale; 0 = no intensity, 8 = extreme intensity)
3. the level of **distress** you experienced during the exercise (0 – 8 scale; 0 = no distress, 8 = extreme distress)
4. the degree of **similarity** to your naturally occurring symptoms (0 – 8 scale; 0 = not at all similar, 8 = extremely similar)

Engage in the exercise *repeatedly*, only waiting long enough in between trials for your symptoms to mostly subside. Continue to repeat the exercise until your *distress* only reaches a 2 or less when you do the exercise. If your distress never reaches above a 2, DO ANYTHING YOU CAN to make the exercise more difficult (e.g., combining the exercises, doing them in front of other people, trying to induce symptoms when you already feel anxious, sad, or upset). You should do **at least** one set of each of the assigned exercises EACH DAY. Instead of watching the clock (which could be used as an emotional avoidance strategy), use a timer or some other type of alarm to help keep track of the time for you, then turn your full attention to the exercise. Use the forms on the following pages to help you chart your trials.

The three exercises you identified as most like symptoms you regularly experience and will practice for exposures are:

1. _____ for _____ seconds
2. _____ for _____ seconds
3. _____ for _____ seconds

Interoceptive Activation Form

DAY 1: _____

Trial	Intensity	Distress	Similarity
1.	_____	_____	_____
2.	_____	_____	_____
3.	_____	_____	_____
4.	_____	_____	_____
5.	_____	_____	_____
6.	_____	_____	_____
7.	_____	_____	_____
8.	_____	_____	_____
9.	_____	_____	_____
10.	_____	_____	_____

DAY 4: _____

Trial	Intensity	Distress	Similarity
1.	_____	_____	_____
2.	_____	_____	_____
3.	_____	_____	_____
4.	_____	_____	_____
5.	_____	_____	_____
6.	_____	_____	_____
7.	_____	_____	_____
8.	_____	_____	_____
9.	_____	_____	_____
10.	_____	_____	_____

DAY 2: _____

Trial	Intensity	Distress	Similarity
1.	_____	_____	_____
2.	_____	_____	_____
3.	_____	_____	_____
4.	_____	_____	_____
5.	_____	_____	_____
6.	_____	_____	_____
7.	_____	_____	_____
8.	_____	_____	_____
9.	_____	_____	_____
10.	_____	_____	_____

DAY 5: _____

Trial	Intensity	Distress	Similarity
1.	_____	_____	_____
2.	_____	_____	_____
3.	_____	_____	_____
4.	_____	_____	_____
5.	_____	_____	_____
6.	_____	_____	_____
7.	_____	_____	_____
8.	_____	_____	_____
9.	_____	_____	_____
10.	_____	_____	_____

DAY 3: _____

Trial	Intensity	Distress	Similarity
1.	_____	_____	_____
2.	_____	_____	_____
3.	_____	_____	_____
4.	_____	_____	_____
5.	_____	_____	_____
6.	_____	_____	_____
7.	_____	_____	_____
8.	_____	_____	_____
9.	_____	_____	_____
10.	_____	_____	_____

DAY 6: _____

Trial	Intensity	Distress	Similarity
1.	_____	_____	_____
2.	_____	_____	_____
3.	_____	_____	_____
4.	_____	_____	_____
5.	_____	_____	_____
6.	_____	_____	_____
7.	_____	_____	_____
8.	_____	_____	_____
9.	_____	_____	_____
10.	_____	_____	_____

Emotional/Situational Avoidance Hierarchy

Describe situations you are currently avoiding in order to prevent uncomfortable emotions from occurring, starting with the worst or most distressing situation. Rate the degree to which you avoid each of the situations you describe, and the degree of distress they cause. For each, write the applicable number in the space provided.

Do Not Avoid	Hesitate To Enter But Rarely Avoid		Sometimes Avoid		Usually Avoid		Always Avoid	
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
No Distress	Slight Distress		Definite Distress		Strong Distress		Extreme Distress	

	Description	Avoid	Distress
1 WORST			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			

Guidelines for Designing and Executing an Effective Emotion Exposure

- I. Choosing your task
 - Pick something that is going to *challenge* you, but don't try to do a task that is too difficult.
 - The purpose of the exercise is to learn that you can master the situation, even in the face of very intense anxiety, fear, or depression.
 - *Always* complete exposures without emotional avoidance strategies, so do something that is manageable.
 - The more difficult exposures you can complete, the better you will do in the long-term.
2. **BEFORE** the exposure
 - As you notice yourself getting nervous before the task, use some of the cognitive reappraisal strategies you learned to reappraise the situation in order to complete the full exposure.
 - Remind yourself that facing your emotions is the only way to make them more manageable.
 - Similarly, if you find that you “just don't want to do it” because you feel depressed or anxious, **THIS IS THE MOMENT TO PUSH YOURSELF EVEN HARDER.** You cannot trust your emotions in this moment –remember that what goes up, must come down.
3. **DURING** the exposure
 - Practice awareness of your thoughts, feelings, behavioral urges, and the situation around you.
 - Prevent yourself from engaging in any emotional avoidance strategies. Don't try to push away uncomfortable thoughts and feelings – they are there and must be experienced head on in order to change and to break the cycle.
 - Notice any EDBs you might have the urge to engage in and do not engage in them. You will be reinforcing the negative cycle of emotions if you do.

- STAY IN THE SITUATION until your emotional distress has reduced. Notice what it's like when your emotions are reducing on their own. See how you are able to make a choice about how you respond, instead of being driven by your feelings.

4. AFTER the exposure

- Look back and evaluate how the exposure went.
- Did what you fear would happen actually happen?
- Did you do anything to prevent your emotions from becoming too intense?
- Did you stay in the exposure long enough?
- What could you have done to challenge yourself even more?

IF YOU FIND YOURSELF AVOIDING THE EXPOSURE, reevaluate your fears by answering some of these questions:

- What did you fear would happen?
- What do you imagine happening that would be so terrible?
- What would be so bad about that happening
- If you could be sure that that is all that would happen, would you still be as afraid of it as you are?

Record of Emotion Exposure Practice

Exposure Task: _____

Prior to the task:

Anticipatory Distress (0 – 8): _____

Thoughts, Feelings, and Behaviors you noticed before the task:

Reevaluate your automatic appraisals about the task:

After completing the task:

Thoughts, Feelings, and Behaviors you noticed during the task:

Number of minutes you did the task: _____

Maximum distress during the task (0 – 8): _____ Distress at the end of the task (0 – 8): _____

Any attempts to avoid your emotions (distraction, safety signals, etc.)?

What did you take away from this exposure task? Did your feared outcomes occur? If so, how were you able to cope with them?

COPING WITH EMOTIONS

This is a card to help you remember the steps for dealing with uncomfortable emotions.

1. Am I anchored in the present?
2. What emotions am I experiencing (the “three-point check”)?
3. What triggered this reaction? What was I doing right before it happened?
4. What are some of my thoughts here? How can I be more flexible in my thinking by considering other alternatives?
5. What is my EDB in this situation? How can I change it?
6. Am I doing anything else to avoid my emotions (e.g., emotional avoidance strategies?). How can I bring awareness to my experience in this situation?

Treatment Review

Important things to remember

- Emotions are *normal, natural, and adaptive*. They provide important information about different types of experiences. For this reason, we would not want to eliminate emotions like anxiety, sadness, and fear – we need them to help us survive.
- Emotions become maladaptive when they are not “in balance” with the situation that is producing them. For example, it would be appropriate to feel some anxiety about preparing for an upcoming test (this anxiety would be useful because it would motivate you to study). However, it would be *maladaptive* if the anxiety was so intense that it *prevented* you from studying or interfered with your ability to concentrate on the test questions. It is important to recognize when your emotions change from adaptive to maladaptive.
- Throughout this treatment, you have learned a variety of techniques to help you combat maladaptive emotions. These include:
 1. Becoming aware of the triggers and consequences of your emotions
 2. Recognizing and clarifying which emotions you are experiencing
 3. Preventing any emotional avoidance strategies that interfere with new learning about the situation
 4. Understanding how you typically react to that experience (EDBs)
 5. Changing how you typically react to emotions by engaging in behaviors that are incompatible with EDBs
- If you understand these principles, you should be able to design and implement your own treatment plan, should you have any future emotional difficulties. Remember though, a “lapse” does not mean you have “relapsed.” Keep it all in perspective, and any time you feel your emotions becoming maladaptive, you know what to do!

